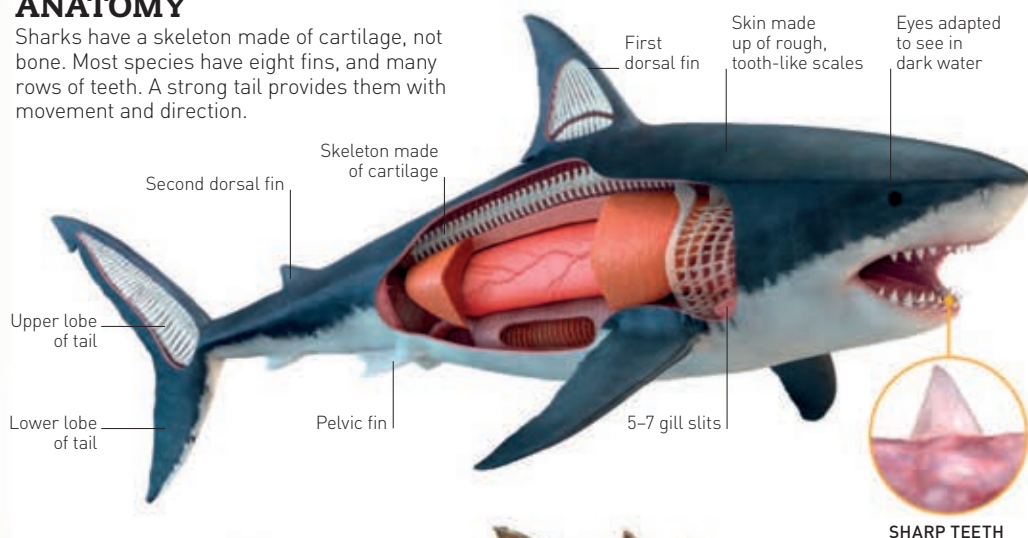


Sharks

Sharks have prowled the oceans for 400 million years, which means they existed before the dinosaurs. In all that time they have hardly changed at all, perhaps because they are so perfectly suited to their environment. There are around 500 different species of sharks.

ANATOMY

Sharks have a skeleton made of cartilage, not bone. Most species have eight fins, and many rows of teeth. A strong tail provides them with movement and direction.



TYPES OF SHARKS

Sharks vary in size enormously. The slow-moving whale shark is about 8 m (26 ft) long, while the dwarf lanternshark is smaller than a human hand. Some eat large animals, such as seals, while others feed on tiny plankton.

